



Relentless run: Spain's victory against Argentina in the final left it unbeaten in 38 matches – a new men's international record. GETTY IMAGES

Yamal entered the tournament carrying expectations that would have burdened far older footballers. His acceleration, disguised passing and fearlessness repeatedly tilted matches before opponents had organised themselves. Yet unlike so many young stars, he was never asked to carry Spain alone. Around him functioned a collective that was entirely free of hierarchy.

Rodri remained the team's metronome, rarely hurried, forever choosing the correct pass before pressure arrived. He has now won the Player of the Tournament both in the Euro and the World Cup. Fabian Ruiz produced perhaps the finest tournament of his career, knitting midfield together while contributing goals and relentless defensive work. Nico Williams stretched defences from the opposite flank whenever he played, while Dani Olmo drifted between lines, creating overloads

wherever Spain needed them. Mikel Oyarzabal provided the goals to soothe down the nerves after the initial draw with Cape Verde.

The full-backs pushed high enough to create width without exposing the defence, and goalkeeper Unai Simón was called upon surprisingly infrequently, a reflection of how effectively those in front of him protected the penalty boxes.

Whenever Spain lost possession, the counter-press arrived almost instinctively, often recovering the ball before opponents could string together three passes.

Every attacker defended. Every defender initiated attacks. Possession, pressing and positional discipline became parts of the same movement rather than separate ideas.

There was also a maturity that distinguished this side from many

previous champions.

Spain rarely chased matches emotionally. It never seemed rushed by the occasion, whether facing Mbappe in Dallas, Belgium in Los Angeles or Messi in the MetLife Stadium. Its football carried the serenity of a team that knew exactly who it was.

For much of the past decade, international football has been shaped by transition, athleticism and chaos. Spain reminded everyone that control still matters. But it also demonstrated that control no longer means simply completing 800 passes.

It means controlling space, tempo, emotions and ultimately the result.

In doing so, De la Fuente's players achieved something larger than lifting the World Cup. They completed Spanish football's evolution.